

★ GENERAL IN THE LABYRINTH ★

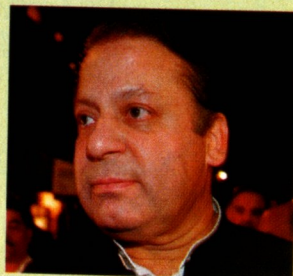
BENAZIR BHUTTO

The PPP leader is willing to support Musharraf as a weakened president once he steps out of uniform. Stands to gain a share of power and also benefit from the ending of corruption cases against her, but may lose credibility and votes for bailing out a military dictator on American prompting.



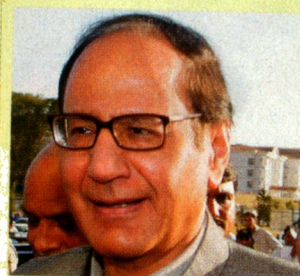
NAWAZ SHARIF

The PML(N) chief is unwilling to countenance Musharraf in any position because of personal history and a high wave of public support. May benefit in polls if he returns but may also face jail back home and incur the displeasure of the Saudi Government which hosted him in exile.



CHAUDHRY SHUJAAT

The PML(Q) leader fears free polls in the face of resurgence of Sharif and Bhutto. Tried to sabotage Bhutto-Musharraf deal and keep the General dependent on him and cousin Pervez Elahi, the Punjab CM. Willing to hobnob with religious lobby. Stands to lose ground in every scenario.



that Musharraf has been forced—through circumstances and from western allies who would like to see the forging of a 'liberal front' in Pakistan to take on the religious hardliners—to consider a compromise with Bhutto, is a strong indicator of the weakened position he finds himself in. Musharraf had made no attempt in the past eight years to hide his revulsion for the self-exiled leader and her alleged involvement in corruption cases. On her part, Bhutto has her own compulsions in dealing with Musharraf, and they are obviously strong enough for her to brave the disenchantment of her party's generally anti-military rank and file. But whether the deal materialises or not—indications are that it probably will and negotiations were on in Dubai even as this issue was going to print—the end result is likely to be a weaker Musharraf.

"One cannot say exactly when the end will come," says an Islamabad-based western diplomat, "it could be a few months or stretch out for another one or two years, but all indications are that things are moving in that direc-

tion." For the first time, the business community, which has long equated prosperity and stability with Musharraf being at the top of affairs, is also willing to look beyond him. "We would still like to see General *sahib* in place for the coming years," says a leading stock market broker who requested anonymity, "but I think we are in a position now that even if he is no longer there, we would survive. I don't think anyone new is going to fundamentally change his policies."

The personal crisis that Musharraf faces has many dimensions and a number of unpredictable stakeholders that make hazarding predictions a very risky matter. From Bhutto and Sharif to disgruntled allies such as PML(Q)'s Chaudhry Shujaat, the incensed mullah lobby of the Muttahida Majlis-e-Amal (MMA), the Supreme Court and the army itself, each player could influence the outcome of events (*see box*). A new, still nascent, factor is the public mood exhibited to a telling effect during the judicial crisis. There are a number of possibilities the

